## Scheduled Castes (SCs)

A number of schemes to encourage SC students to continue their studies from school to higher education level as well as for the economic advancement of needy SC families are under implementation. The Post-Matric scheme has been revised with effect from July 1, 2010 so as to:

(i) Raise the parental annual income ceiling for eligibility from Rs. 1 lakh to Rs. 2 lakh,

(ii) Rationalise the grouping of courses, and

(iii) Upwardly revise maintenance and other allowances by 60 per cent.

Under the Rajiv Gandhi National Fellowship Scheme which aims at providing financial assistance to SC students pursuing M. Phil and PhD courses, the number of scholarships. The specified subjects under National Overseas Scholarships have been revised for the selection year 2010-11 and new subjects, namely medicine, pure sciences, engineering, agricultural sciences, and management have been specified for providing financial assistance to students pursuing master's-level courses and PhD/post-doctoral courses abroad.

The Scheme of Top Class Education for SCs provides financial assistance for quality education to SC students up to degree/post-degree level. SC students who secure admission in notified institutions are awarded scholarships. Twenty-four new institutions have been added to the notified list of premier institutions under the scheme with effect from the current financial year. The total number of specified institutions has thus increased to 205. Under the revised Babu Jagjivan Ram Chhatrawas Yojna,' a centrally sponsored scheme for hostels for SC boys and girls, assistance for the construction of girls hostels has been raised from 50 per cent to 100 per cent.

Special Central Assistance to the Scheduled Castes Sub Plan is a major scheme for economic advancement of SCs. The main thrust is on economic development of the SC population in order to bring them above the poverty line through self-employment or training. The amount of subsidy admissible under the scheme is 50 per cent of the project cost, subject to a maximum of Rs. 10,000 per beneficiary.